From the Indian perspective, whether it was the exercise of the nuclear option, a security concern like Afghanistan or the politics of the Indian subcontinent, British diplomacy was understandably viewed with suspicion. Moreover, as it gradually came into its own, the desire to put the past behind was also commensurately stronger in Indian politics. Weakening bonds between the elites as a result of deeper democratization of India accelerated the process. By the time Brexit arrived, the case for setting new terms of engagement was apparent.

While the past continues to cast its shadow, the present is not without its own complications. British politics is often driven by vote-bank considerations, though not to the extreme extent of Canada. And this has given space for secessionist forces targeting India to operate from its soil and misuse its freedoms. Ideological hostility in influential quarters against the current dispensation in India has also added to irritants. Some are visibly so resentful of changes in India that they do not wish to understand the reality. When the UK claims to have a special bond with India, its impact is all the more.

However, there is also a parallel reality of the two nations cooperating in a range of domains. This long-standing duality is one of the characteristics of the ties; whether the UK would follow the US to comprehensively reset it is the major question. Till now, the UK has lagged behind, but there is growing consciousness of the distance that this has created with India. Making adjustments requires introspection on a range of concerns, from political sensitivities and security issues to export controls and mobility. That this is no longer the India of the past should be evident by now. Whether it is replacing British-era legal codes, expressing its cultural beliefs or asserting the symbolism of Netaji, times are surely changing. Because of the close past association, it is particularly incumbent on the UK to appreciate the nature of this transformation.

On the other hand, it is also essential that Indians approach the future of this partnership more clinically. They must recognize that the UK has served as an effective gateway for Indian businesses in Europe and that it hosts a successful diaspora. Its global influence may not be the same, but it is still very real in parts of the world. In certain domains, British technology and capabilities are clearly world-class. From an Indian viewpoint, there is a case for building further on the convergence that the two countries may currently have. That answer, once both countries put their mind to it, veers